

Time Shifting

The telephone always rings at the wrong time, doesn't it? People only think of calling when you are in the shower or while you are watching your favourite show on the telly. When it comes to the shower, you're on your own, but you never need miss another minute of your favourite TV shows.

Wouldn't it be cool to be your own third umpire when watching a cricket match? No need to wait for the replay: just replay the last ball automatically on your own! Perhaps you would also love to skip or fast-forward advertisements?

All the above is easy with a TV tuner card. All you need to do is invest in a TV tuner card that offers time-shifting features. Previously, this was only possible using a set-top box such as the TiVo. However, today, PVR software is all you need.

So, how does it work? While you watch your favourite show the audio and video is saved to your hard disk in real-time. But this is

where the similarity between video capturing and time-shifting ends. Time-shifting lets you view the recorded content while the recording is being done. Thus, when you pause the video, the recording continues, and when you press play, the delayed video is played back.

However, the quality of the time-shifted video always seems to be inferior to live video. This quality depends on the video capture format selected in the capture settings of the PVR software. A better capture format such as MPEG-2 at DVD resolution would result in better quality, but would need a high-end system to run.

Also, the time duration for which a programme can be paused depends on the free space available on the hard drive. Time-shifting is critically dependent on processor speed and hard disk speed, but today, with even entry level PCs being shipped with sufficiently high processing power CPUs, this has become a non-issue.

All the TV tuners came with connecting cables. Some, such as the Tech-Com card, came with an S-video to S-video and a 3 to 1 AV cable in addition to the stereo cable, while the PixelView Media-Centre PlayTV@P3000 came with just a stereo cable. The software packages also varied; while many TV tuners came with just the drivers and no-nonsense PVR software, some, such as the Compro VideoMate Gold Plus II, came with Ulead's MovieFactory 2 SE and VideoStudio 2 SE DVD software.



Compro VideoMate PVR/FM

The MSI Mega TVTuner Card came with InterVideo WinCinema Suite—a great software package.

All the cards came with PVR software that had MPEG-1 and 2 capture capabilities, with the exception of Mercury—it could not capture to MPEG-2. Some

cards, such as the AVerMedia, PixelView PlayTV Pro 2 and Tech-Com, also supported MPEG-4 capturing.

As far as looks go, the Compro Videomate Gold II and Gold Plus II stand out from the crowd with their gold plating. The Pinnacle and MSI cards had sleek looking tuner units—the Pinnacle was the sleekest. This

is an advantage because a sleek form factor leaves more room for air circulation between adjacent cards and the cabinet on the whole.

Performance

Almost all the cards performed well. The ease of installation of the drivers and PVR were noted. We were very disappointed by the Mercury card, as we had a tough time installing the drivers and PVR software.

When we installed the Pinnacle PCTV Rave on our other test machine, it couldn't initialise properly after the driver installation, and hence refused to work. The device manager showed that it had a problem. You have to be careful when buying such a card.

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